

Contractor Quote Comparison Playbook

Price, scope, allowances, exclusions, warranties and payment terms

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Plan first. Price second.

This 12-page field guide is designed to be used beside HomeCostEngine calculators, measurements, product selections and contractor proposals. It does not try to replace a site inspection or local professional. Instead, it helps you make assumptions visible so quotes become easier to understand and compare.

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Use this guide for planning and education only. Verify final pricing, code, permits, suitability and scope with qualified local professionals.

HIRING AND QUOTES

Create one bid scope

Give bidders the same project description, drawings, product assumptions and requested alternates. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for asking each contractor to define the project differently and then comparing totals. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Issue one baseline scope.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

What is the one assumption on this page that could change your price or contractor scope? Write it down before moving to the next chapter.

HIRING AND QUOTES

Normalize price categories

Move each quote into common categories such as demolition, labor, materials, permits, disposal and finish work. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for comparing headline totals with different inclusions. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Create a side-by-side comparison sheet.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Separate allowances

Identify every placeholder allowance and the quantity or quality it assumes. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for a low quote supported by unrealistically small fixture or finish allowances. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Compare fixed scope separately from allowances.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

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HIRING AND QUOTES

Read exclusions carefully

Treat exclusions as future cost exposure that must be assigned to someone. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for important work hidden in small-print exclusions. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Convert exclusions into owner tasks or added contractor prices.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Compare payment terms

Review deposit, progress milestones, retainage, change-order billing and final payment triggers. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for large front-loaded payments not tied to completed work. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Map each payment to a documented milestone.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Compare warranties and qualifications

Separate product, manufacturer and workmanship warranties and verify licensing or insurance where applicable. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for assuming the longest warranty automatically means the lowest risk. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Compare documentation and scope, not marketing language alone.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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HIRING AND QUOTES

Resolve uncertainty before signing

Create a list of unclear items and obtain written answers or revised proposals.

The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for signing with unresolved scope because the start date feels urgent. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total.

Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Close every material question or assign a written allowance.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Project checklist

Resolve or document each item before you approve the final scope or purchase decision.

- Common bid scope
- Price categories normalized
- Allowances identified
- Exclusions assigned
- Payment milestones
- Warranty details
- Open questions resolved

CHECKPOINT

Any unchecked item is not automatically a problem. It is a prompt to clarify responsibility, price or assumptions in writing before money is committed.

WORKING DOCUMENT

Budget worksheet

Keep planned amounts, actual quotes and notes together. Do not hide allowances or contingency inside one total.

Quote A total	Planned: \$ _____
Quote B total	Planned: \$ _____
Quote C total	Planned: \$ _____
Allowances	Planned: \$ _____
Excluded work	Planned: \$ _____
Permit responsibility	Planned: \$ _____
Payment terms	Planned: \$ _____
Warranty notes	Planned: \$ _____

Update this worksheet whenever a quote, selection or change order changes the project.

Next steps

You now have a practical framework for hiring and quotes planning. Move from generic assumptions to real measurements, written product selections and comparable local proposals as your project becomes more defined.

Use HomeCostEngine next

- Run the relevant free calculator at homecostengine.com.
- Compare contractor proposals with matching scope and allowances.
- Keep a separate contingency instead of hiding uncertainty inside fixed costs.
- Save this guide with your quotes, selections and final project records.

HOME COST PLANNING - CLEARER ASSUMPTIONS - BETTER QUESTIONS

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Educational planning resource only. Always verify project-specific decisions with qualified local professionals.